

PROJECT The 20-point website checklist	DRAWN BY Caleb Bolden • calebbolden.com	SHEET checklist 01	REV A
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Does your website turn visitors into calls?

Work through this list in an afternoon; no code required for most of it. Visitors decide fast: eye-tracking research puts the first impression at a fraction of a second, and a HubSpot analysis of 40,000+ landing pages found calls-to-action visible without scrolling convert about 30% better. Most local business sites fail on the basics below, which means fixing them is a real edge, not table stakes. Ordered by impact.

A Get the phone right

- 01 ☐ **Make your phone number a tap-to-call link in the header of every page.** For local businesses, calls convert at a multiple of web forms, and most local calls now start from a tap on a phone screen.
 - 02 ☐ **Make the number visually obvious, not buried in footer small print.** Nearly half of consumers move on to a competitor when they can't find a phone number quickly during a mobile search.
 - 03 ☐ **Call your own number from a cell phone.** How many rings? Voicemail? An observational study of 85 small businesses found only 38% of calls get answered live. If that is you, a missed-call text-back tool costs less than one lost job a month.
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B Pass the five-second test

- 04 ☐ **State what you do, for whom, and where in one sentence at the top of the homepage.** "Same-day plumbing repairs in Fort Worth" beats your business name and a stock photo.
- 05 ☐ **Put one clear call-to-action above the fold.** Call, book, or get a quote. Pick the one action you most want and make it a button.
- 06 ☐ **Repeat that same call-to-action mid-page and at the bottom.** One ask, three placements, instead of three different asks.
- 07 ☐ **Ask a stranger to look at your homepage for five seconds, then tell you what you sell.** If they can't, rewrite the headline before touching anything else.

C Remove the friction

- 08 ☐ **Get your homepage loading in under 3 seconds on a phone.** Test at pagespeed.web.dev. Conversion studies put the cost of each extra second past that at roughly 10% of your conversions.
- 09 ☐ **Check the site on an actual phone, not a shrunk browser window.** Buttons big enough for thumbs, no sideways scrolling, no pinch-zooming to read.
- 10 ☐ **Cut your contact form to 5 fields or fewer, and label anything optional as optional.** HubSpot's form research found going from 3 required fields to 4 nearly halved completions.
- 11 ☐ **Offer online booking if you take appointments.** A large share of service appointments get booked outside business hours; phone-only booking hands those to a competitor with a booking page.
- 12 ☐ **Confirm the padlock (https) shows on every page.** Roughly a quarter of small business sites still get this wrong, and browsers warn visitors away from them.
- 13 ☐ **Submit your own contact form this week, and again monthly.** Silently broken forms are one of the most common and most invisible ways local sites lose leads.

D Prove you're real

- 14 ☐ **Use real photos: your team, your trucks, your shop, your finished work.** Stock photography is one of the strongest "template site" signals; real photos are one of the strongest trust signals.
- 15 ☐ **Put 3 to 5 real reviews with names on the homepage itself.** In BrightLocal's consumer survey work, visible reviews are the top trust signal driving the decision to contact.
- 16 ☐ **Prefer specific testimonials over generic praise.** "Fixed our AC the same day in July" does work that "great service!" cannot.
- 17 ☐ **Show your license number, insurance, and certifications near your call-to-action.** For service businesses these are decision-making shortcuts, not decoration.
- 18 ☐ **Add a short about section with your name, your face, and years in business.** People hire people, especially locally.

E Keep it alive

- 19 ☐ **Delete or update anything on the site more than a year stale.** Old prices, past events, "coming soon" pages make visitors wonder if you're still open.
- 20 ☐ **Give each core service its own short page instead of one crowded homepage.** Clearer for visitors now, and the foundation local SEO builds on.

Scoring yourself

17+ checks: your site is ahead of most local competitors; spend your energy on the local SEO checklist instead. 10 to 16: a focused weekend closes most of the gap; start with the phone and speed items. Under 10: the site is probably working against you, and it is worth deciding whether to fix or rebuild before spending anything on ads or SEO.

Want an honest outside read?

Send me your website address and I will reply with the three things I would fix first. Free, no obligation.

calebbolden.com/contact

Caleb Bolden builds websites for local small businesses and consults on AI and process automation. The best website is the one that makes the phone ring.